

NATURE & NATIONAL PARKS · A DATA STORY

Australia's Wild Quarter

A young country has quietly placed almost a quarter of its land — and half of its ocean — under protection. This is the story of how, and where the gaps remain.

An interactive visualisation by **Gaurav** · Monash University, FIT2179 Data Visualisation 2 · May 2026

22.6%

of Australia's land
was inside
protected areas in
2024

49%

of Australia's
oceans are
now marine
protected
areas

600+

national parks
span every state
and territory

1879

Royal National
Park — the
world's second
national park

INTRODUCTION

Protecting a continent, one park at a time

National parks are where Australians meet their own country: the desert ranges, rainforest gorges, alpine meadows and rugged coasts that define the place. They are also a promise — a decision to keep parts of the continent wild for the species that live there and the people who come after us.

That promise has grown remarkably fast. In 2004, barely a tenth of Australia's land was protected. Today it is more than a fifth, and the country has pledged to reach **30% by 2030**. Yet the green is spread

unevenly: some states shelter nearly half their land, others less than a tenth.

This visualisation follows that green across the map, back through time, and into the parks themselves — who looks after them, who visits them, and what they are racing to save.

PART ONE · THE MAP

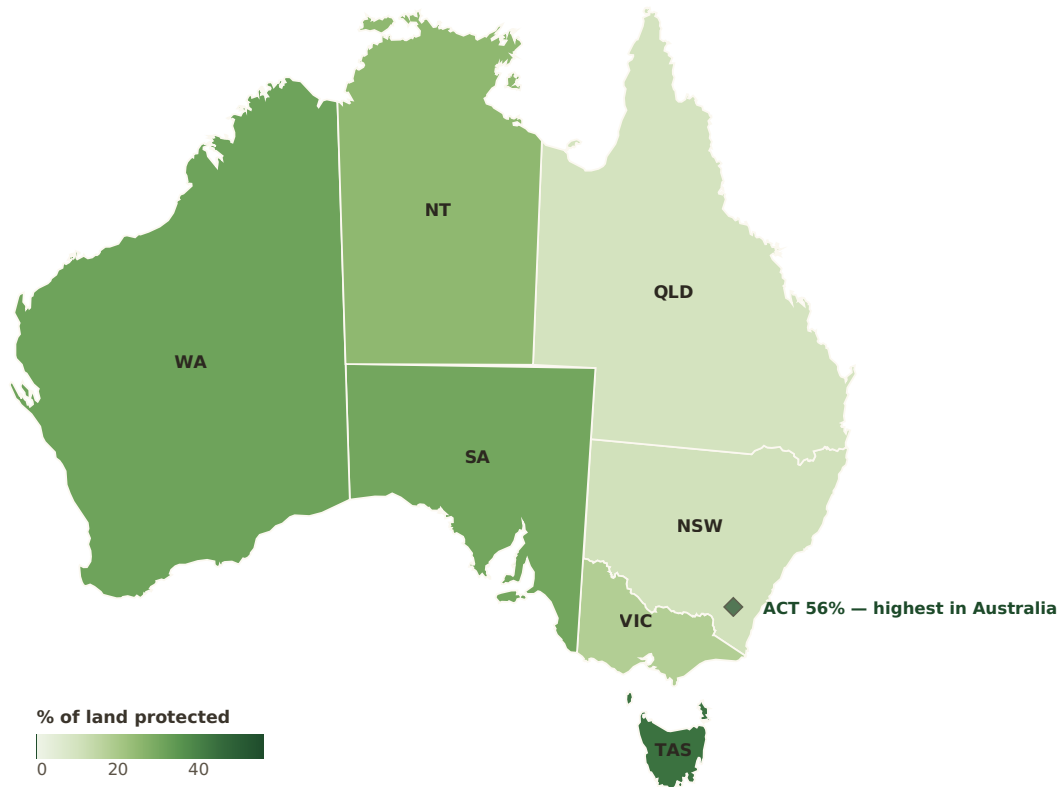
A continent of uneven green

Protected land is not shared equally. The Australian Capital Territory leads the nation, with **56%** of its small footprint protected, followed by Tasmania (43%) and the vast, arid west and centre. The fertile, heavily farmed east tells the opposite story: Queensland and New South Wales each protect under 11% of their land.

Hover over any state to read its exact figure. The pattern is clear — the more a landscape is wanted for farming and cities, the harder it is to protect.

A continent of uneven green

Share of land inside protected areas, by state and territory (CAPAD, 2024). The arid, lightly populated jurisdictions guar



How to read it Darker greens mark a higher share of land protected. The Australian Capital Territory is too small to shade and is shown as a labelled marker. Source: Collaborative Australian Protected Areas Database (CAPAD), DCCEEW, 2024.

PART TWO · THE CLIMB

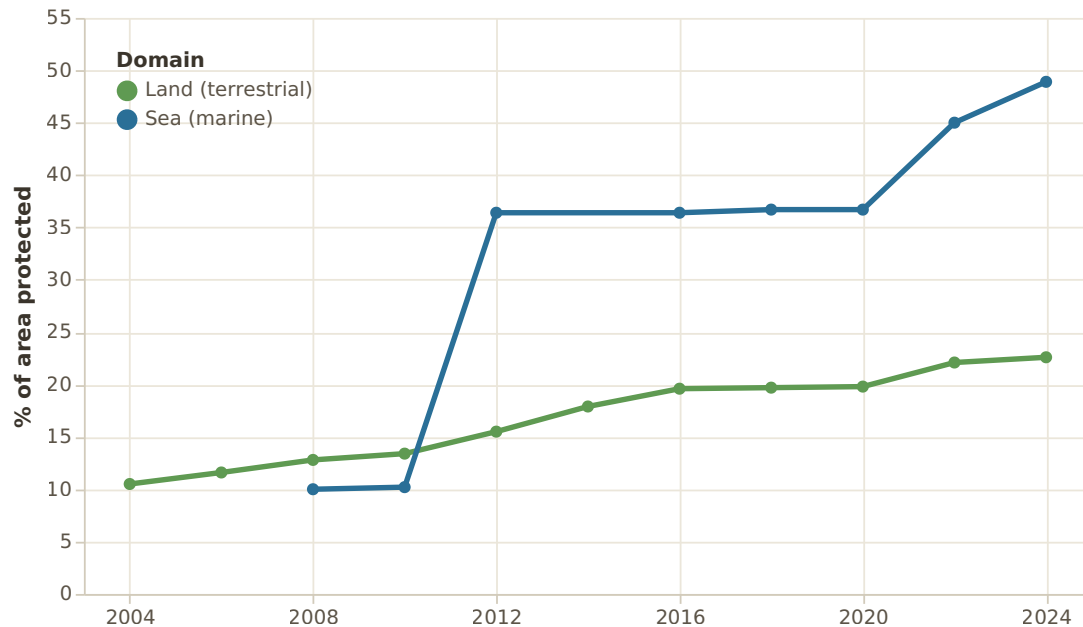
Two decades of rapid protection

The growth has been steep. Since 2004 the protected share of Australia's land has doubled, while marine protection leapt even faster — from a tenth of the ocean to almost half. A run of large additions in 2012 and again after 2020 reshaped the seas around the continent.

On land, the climb has been steadier. At 22.6% in 2024, Australia sits a little over halfway to its 2030 target of protecting 30% of its landmass.

Two decades of rapid protection

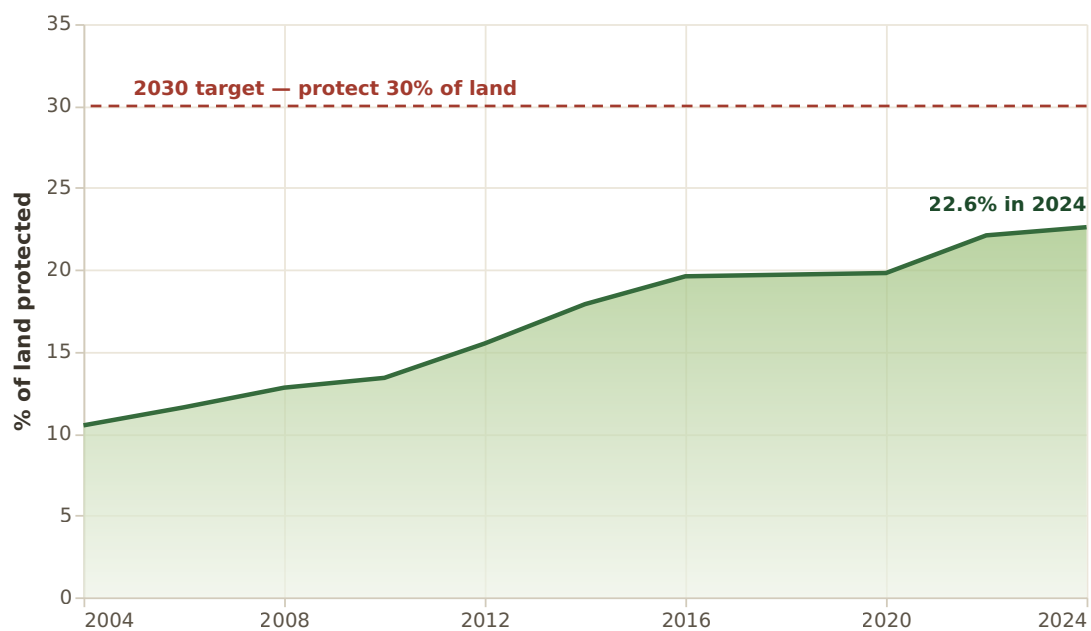
Proportion of Australia's land and ocean inside protected areas, 2004–2024 (ABS / CAPAD).



Land & sea Marine protection now outpaces protection on land. Source: ABS, "Protected areas", 2025, drawing on CAPAD.

Halfway to the 2030 promise

Land inside protected areas has doubled since 2004. Australia has pledged to protect 30% of its land



The 2030 promise The dashed line marks the national 30%-by-2030 commitment.
Source: ABS / CAPAD, 2025.

PART THREE • THE CUSTODIANS

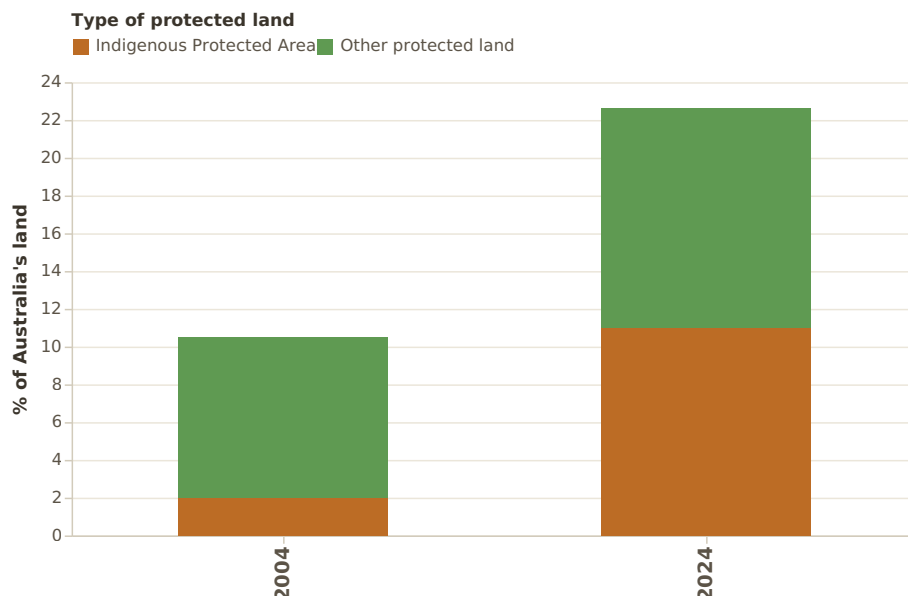
Who is doing the protecting?

Behind the headline numbers is a quieter shift. Much of the new protected land is not a conventional national park at all, but an **Indigenous Protected Area** — Country managed by Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander groups according to their own objectives, and counted as part of the National Reserve System.

In 2004 these areas covered just 2% of the continent. Twenty years on they cover 11% — the single largest driver of Australia's expanding reserve system.

Who is doing the protecting?

Indigenous Protected Areas grew from 2% to 11% of the landmass — the single biggest driver of Australia's expanding r



A growing role Indigenous Protected Areas grew five-fold as a share of the landmass between 2004 and 2024. Source: ABS / CAPAD; DCCEEW, Indigenous Protected Areas.

PART FOUR • THE GIANTS

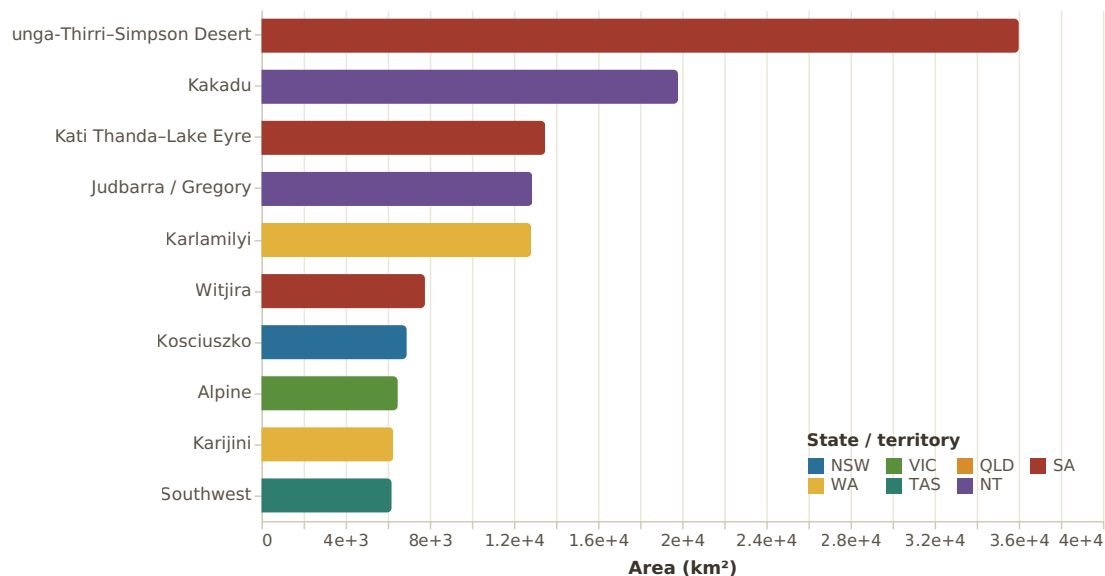
The ten largest national parks

Australia's biggest parks are almost unimaginably large. Munga-Thirri–Simpson Desert National Park in South Australia covers 36,000 km² — bigger than Belgium. Kakadu, the country's best-known wilderness, is a distant second.

Notice where they sit. The giants are clustered in the arid interior and the tropical north, far from the coastal cities — exactly the land that few people want for anything else.

The ten giants

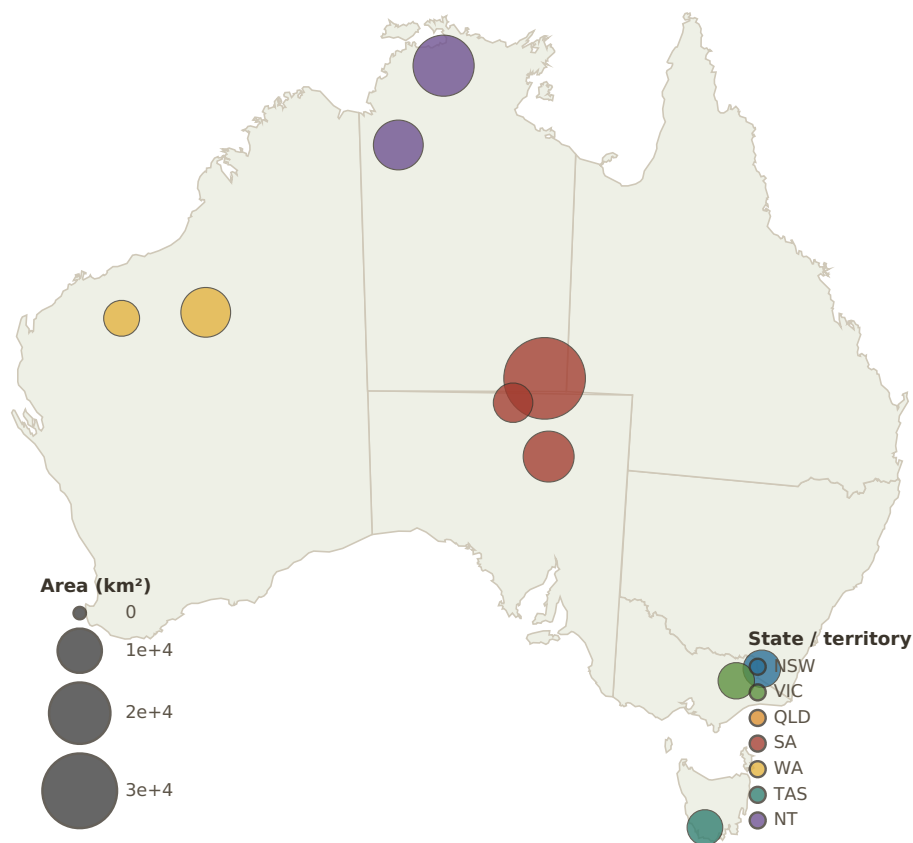
Australia's largest national parks by area (km²). The biggest are deep in the arid interior — not on the popular coast.



By area The ten largest national parks, ranked. Source: Parks Australia & state park agencies, 2025.

Where the giants lie

The ten largest national parks, sized by area and placed at their approximate centre. The desert heart of the country.



By place The same ten parks, sized by area at their approximate centre. Source: Parks Australia & state park agencies, 2025.

PART FIVE · THE HISTORY

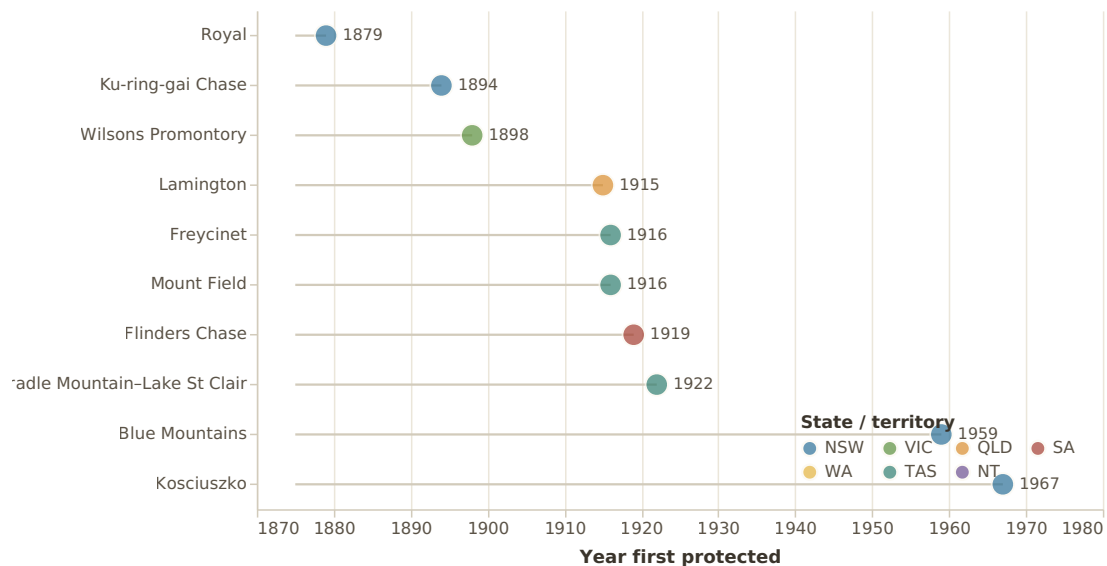
A protection habit, more than a century old

Australia took to national parks early. Royal National Park, south of Sydney, was reserved in 1879 — the second national park anywhere in the world, after Yellowstone. A scatter of others followed before 1920.

But the real surge came much later. The environmental movement of the 1970s and 1980s turned a habit into a wave: more well-known parks were established in the 1980s than in any decade before or since.

Protection began early

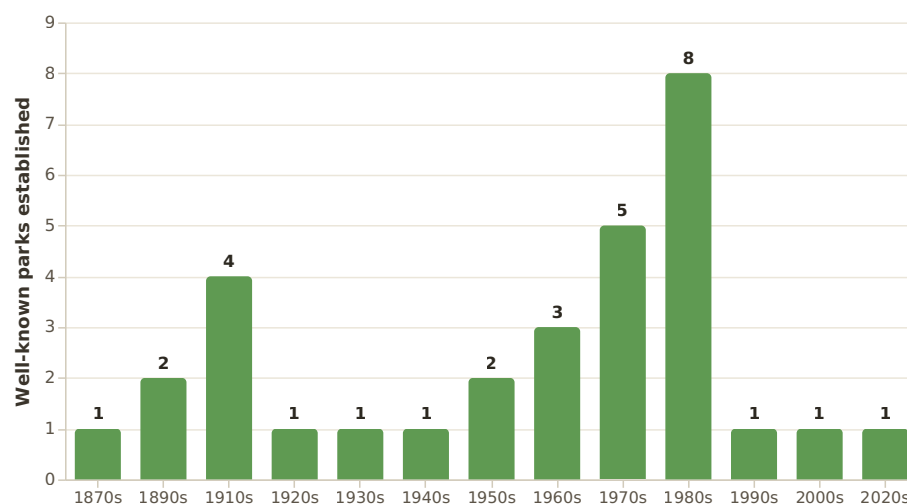
Royal National Park (1879) was the world's second national park. Ten of Australia's oldest parks and the year each was first protected.



The pioneers Ten of the oldest national parks and the year each was first reserved. Source: National Museum of Australia; state park agencies.

The great parks boom

Decade of establishment for 31 of Australia's best-known national parks. The 1970s–80s environmental movement resulted in a significant increase in the number of parks established.



The boom Decade of establishment for 31 well-known national parks. Source: state park agencies, compiled 2025.

PART SIX • THE VISITORS

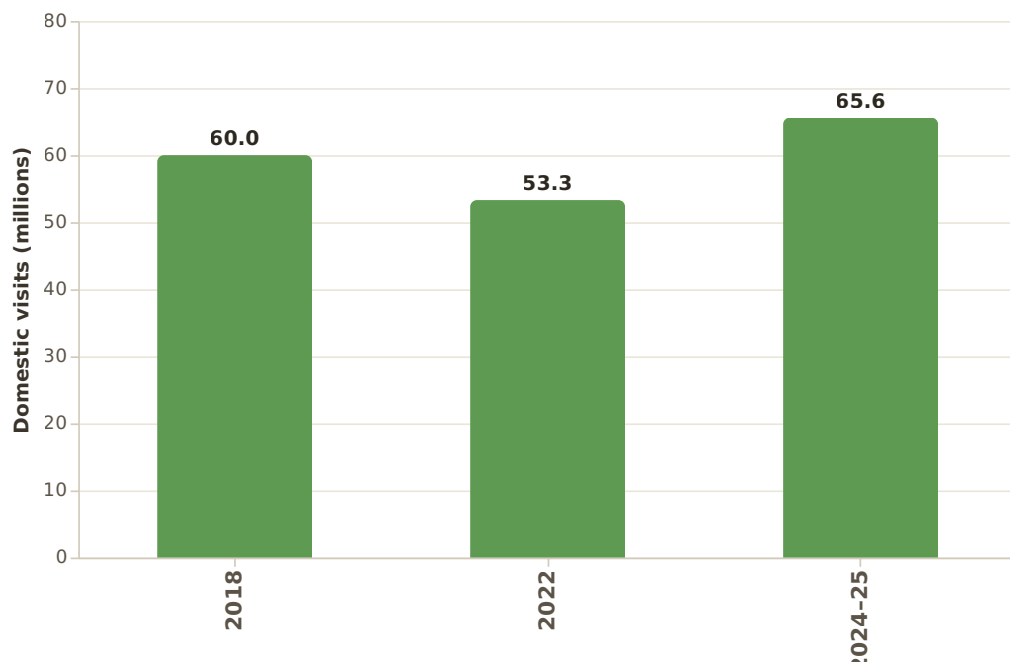
A nation that loves its parks

Protected land is not locked away — Australians pour into it. New South Wales alone recorded a remarkable **65.6 million** domestic visits to its national parks in 2024–25, a new record, after a dip caused by the Black Summer bushfires and pandemic closures.

Visitors are not only locals: almost three-quarters of overseas tourists to NSW now spend time in a national park. And the crowds concentrate — four of the five busiest parks sit on Sydney's doorstep.

A record-breaking comeback

Domestic visits to New South Wales national parks (millions). After a bushfire-and-pandemic dip, visits hit a



The comeback Domestic visits to NSW national parks. Source: NSW National Parks & Wildlife Service, 2025.

Locals lead, the world follows

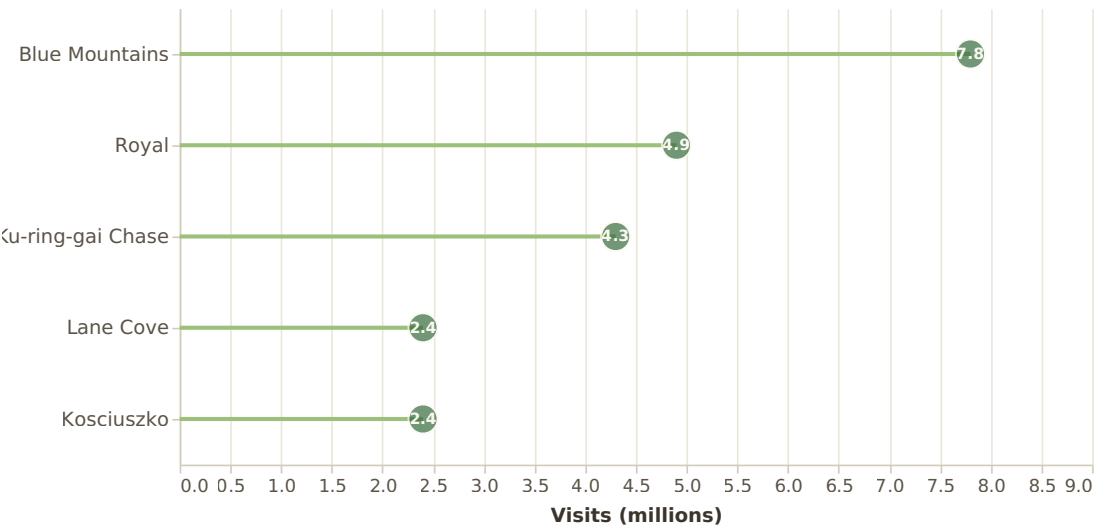
NSW national park visits in 2024-25 (millions). Almost three-quarters of overseas tourists to NSW visited at least one



Who visits NSW park visits in 2024-25, by visitor type. Source: NSW National Parks & Wildlife Service, 2025.

The crowd favourites

The five most-visited national parks in NSW, 2024-25 (millions of visits). Four of the five sit on Sydney's doorstep



The favourites The five most-visited national parks in New South Wales, 2024-25. Source: NSW National Parks & Wildlife Service, 2025.

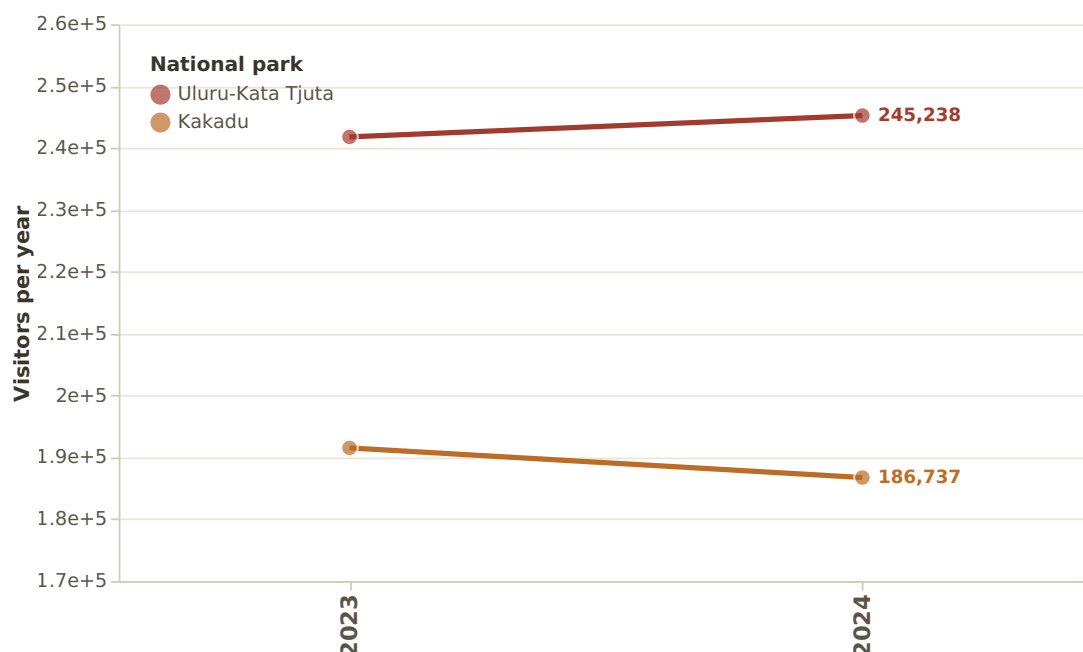
Two icons, two directions

Not every famous park is booming. The Northern Territory's two flagship parks — both managed jointly with their Traditional Owners and both on the World Heritage list — have moved in opposite directions. Uluru-Kata Tjuta edged upward in 2024; Kakadu slipped.

For remote parks that depend on long-haul visitors, small annual swings like these shape the budgets and jobs of whole communities.

Two icons, two directions

Annual visitors to the Northern Territory's flagship parks. Uluru-Kata Tjuta edged up; Kakadu slipped.



Year on year Annual visitor numbers, 2023 to 2024. Source: Parks Australia visitor data, 2024.

PART EIGHT • THE REASON

What the parks are racing to save

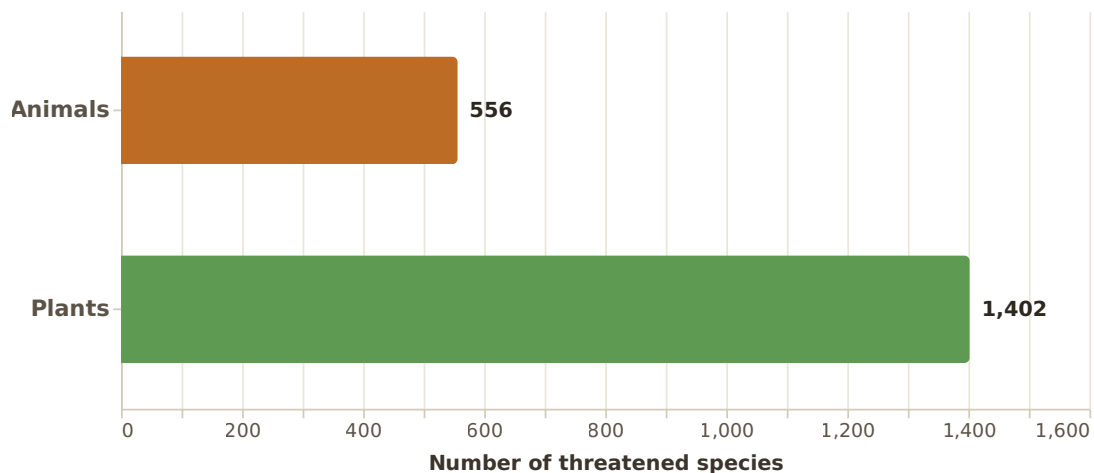
In the end, protected areas exist for the living things inside them. Australia is one of the most biologically distinctive places on Earth —

and one of the most under pressure. More than **2,100 species** are now listed as threatened under national environment law.

Plants make up the larger share of that list, but the losses are spread across mammals, birds, frogs, reptiles and fish. Every well-placed park is a piece of the safety net.

What the parks are racing to save

Species listed as threatened under national environment law (EPBC Act). The full list has since passed 2,



The stakes Species listed as threatened under the EPBC Act, by group. Source: DCCEEW, EPBC Act threatened species list; Biodiversity Council Australia.

IN CLOSING

Halfway up the mountain

Australia's protected estate is a genuine national achievement — doubled in a generation, increasingly led by Indigenous custodians, and loved by tens of millions of visitors a year. But the map still has thin spots exactly where life is busiest, and the 30%-by-2030 target is not yet won.

The wild quarter is not a finished thing. It is a promise still being kept.

About this visualisation

This data story was created for **FIT2179 Data Visualisation 2** at Monash University. It uses the **Vega-Lite** grammar of graphics for every chart and map. Each chart's JSON specification is published, human-readable, in the /charts folder of this repository; the map geometry is in /data.

Why

Australians care deeply about national parks but rarely see the national picture — how much is protected, where, and how fast it is changing. This visualisation makes that picture visible.

Who

Designed for a general Australian audience: residents, travellers and students curious about the country's natural places. No specialist or statistical knowledge is assumed.

What

Real, recent, public data combining two main sources — the Collaborative Australian Protected Areas Database (CAPAD) and national-park visitor statistics — with biodiversity and park-history data.

How

Munzer's framework guided the idioms: choropleth and proportional-symbol maps for spatial tasks, lines and areas for trends, and bar, lollipop and slope charts for comparison and change.

Data sources

- ABS — [Protected areas \(2025\)](#), based on CAPAD
- DCCEEW — [Collaborative Australian Protected Areas Database \(CAPAD\)](#)
- NSW NPWS — [Record visits to NSW national parks \(2025\)](#)
- Parks Australia & state park agencies — park areas, history and visitor data

- DCCEEW — [Threatened species under the EPBC Act](#)
- State boundary geometry — world-geojson (Natural Earth derived), simplified by the author

Method & tools

All charts and maps were built with Vega-Lite 5. The map uses a conic equal-area projection appropriate for Australia. Boundary data was simplified to keep the page fast to load.

Each Vega-Lite specification is available, formatted for human readability, in this [GitHub repository](#).

Authorship

Gaurav

Monash University — FIT2179 Data Visualisation 2
Semester 1, 2026 · Published May 2026

Released for assessment purposes. You are welcome to reuse the underlying public data with attribution to its original sources.

Use of AI: Generative AI tools were used to assist with proofreading and refining the narrative text, scaffolding the Vega-Lite JSON specifications, and processing the boundary geometry. All data selection, story design, analysis and final decisions are the author's own work. | Data current as at 2024–25 where available. | © 2026 Gaurav.